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California ethnic studies curriculum faces changes after backlash

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State schools superintendent Tony Thurmond on Wednesday, Aug. 14 called for major revisions to a draft ethnic studies curriculum that has been lambasted by Jewish American organizations as biased and anti-Semitic.

The superintendent was flanked at a press conference by members of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, which criticized the draft they say omits the Jewish experience, fails to discuss anti-Semitism, singles out Israel for criticism and reinforces negative stereotypes about Jews.

None of that was intentional, Thurmond said.

"The Jewish experience has a place in this curriculum and in all of our conversations," Thurmond said.

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Revisions to the draft, which would be used as a model for school districts statewide to create their own ethnic studies curriculum, could also include the stories of other minority groups.

"We are being contacted by many groups that feel that their story needs to be told," Thurmond said.

A traditional framework for ethnic studies focuses on African Americans, Latino Americans, Asian Americans and Native Americans.

"I think the task for us will be to establish California's version of what ethnic studies looks like and how we have a conversation," Thurmond said.

Earlier this week, the State Board of Education issued a statement saying that the draft "falls short and needs to be substantially redesigned."

A Board of Education advisory commission has gotten some 5,000 comments on the draft. The deadline to send a comment is Thursday, Aug. 15.

But the curriculum, required by a 2016 law, still has a long way to go. Thurmond said the department may need to ask the legislature for more time, hire new writers and, if needed, start a new draft.

Thurmond's comments pleased members of the Jewish Caucus.

"This draft curriculum was really insulting," Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, who represents the west San Fernando Valley, said in a phone interview Wednesday. "And to the Jewish community, anti-Semitism is not theoretical. We are facing it now."

More than a dozen forms of discrimination were listed in the draft. Anti-Semitism was not among them. And when Jews or Israel were mentioned, critics said, the examples institutionalized anti-Semitic stereotypes – all at a time when there is a rise in hate crimes against Jews, including attacks on synagogues. The draft, for example, recommends a rap song that deals with the Israeli-Palestinian conflict and appears to enforce an old stereotype: that Jews control the news media.

"This curriculum is supposed to be about teaching young people ... and we're going to go and put in a song lyric

that extends anti-Semitic tropes? How crazy would that be," Sen. Ben Allen, D-Santa Monica, who chairs the Jewish Caucus, said in a phone interview.

More than 80 Jewish organizations wrote to complain about the draft curriculum. But the Jewish community was not alone. Armenian, Hindu, Korean and Hellenic civic groups issued a joint statement this week calling on the Department of Education to rewrite the draft they said is "replete with mischaracterizations and omissions of major California ethno-religious groups."

"California high school students deserve an opportunity to learn the role of ethnicity, race and religion in the life of all its citizens, including those previously ignored. But the proposed Ethnic Studies Model Curriculum, in its current form, does not come close to achieving this admirable goal," said the letter from seven organizations, including the Armenian Assembly of America, the American Hellenic Council, the Hindu American Foundation and the Korean American Coalition.

"The draft lacks cultural competency, does not reflect California's diverse population and advances a political agenda that should not be taught as unchallenged truth in our state's public schools," the organizations wrote.

While state educators work on creating a curriculum, state legislators are considering a bill introduced by Assemblymember Jose Medina, D-Riverside, to make a semester of ethnic studies a requirement for graduation.

Medina, a former ethnic studies teacher and a member of the Jewish caucus, joined Allen, Gabriel and others Wednesday morning in Sacramento. He wants to see a mandatory ethnic studies class required. But not this version.

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